Soon, a committee was constituted to identify a suitable place to set up India's first integrated liquid propulsion test complex. Among the shortlisted places were Kottur, Kallada and Kannur in kerala, Tirupati, and Chandrayangutta in Andhra Pradesh, Puri and Balasore in Orissa, Mahendragiri and Vellore in Tamil Nadu, and Kutch in Gujarat.

Kutch was rejected in the initial screening for its proximity to the Pakistan border. Kallada, not too far from Trivandrum, was also taken off the list because of the presence of a dam that stored water for drinking; many other places were also ruled out because of environmental factors and proximity to thickly populated areas.

While in a few places there was opposition from environment groups and locals, ironically, in Kerala, there was a reverse argument—that I was trying to take away the proposed facility out of Kerala. Some of the Malayalam newspapers came up with the 'investigative report' that both Muthunayagam, the liquid propulsion centre chief and me, his deputy were from Tamil Nadu, and hence we wanted the project in that state. Little did they know that my father had lived in Kerala, and I did it most of my life. And most of the parts now in southern Tamil Nadu were then in Kerala, which meant my forefathers considered both the states their home. Anyway, these were things I didn't have time or inclination to educate the media about.

But when Kerala politicians echoed these arguments, I presented myself to a gathering of law makers and influential people.

'I want this as close to Trivandrum,' I said, 'not because of any love for any state, but I feel it should be close to our parent body of VSSC here.'

The audience nodded.

'Now, here are the conditions: the complex will be handling highly toxic substances and doing tests that have a nominal risk of causing explosions. We will need hundreds of acres of land, and there should be no habitation in the radius of several kilometers of the facility. And yes, there should not be any drinking water sources in the vicinity because the fuel we use is cancer causing, and there will be many more toxic substances being handled at the facility.'